the Chinese knew that once the fighting started, the unprotected Mi-4s would have to abandon the troops. Not only was the quantum of Indian troops facing the Chinese minuscule, it was also obvious that there would be no reinforcements.

In their overall scheme of annexing and then linking Tibet and Sinkiang, the occupation of Aksai Chin was a critical factor. After having built National Highway G219 it was equally important to put the Indians in the immediate vicinity of the Karakorams in a strategically difficult, if not impossible position.

The main characteristic of the Galwan theatre when compared to DBO and Qara Qash was that the Karakoram Range in this area is geographically far better defined. The Galwan River pierces through this imposing natural barrier forty-eight kilometres to the east of the Galwan-Shyok river junction. To the south, the Karakoram Range then splits into two—Karakoram I separating the Kugrang River from the Changlung while Karakoram II, also known as the Nischu Mountains, runs along the left bank of the Changlung River. The slope from the crest line of the Karakoram to the Shyok River was too far for the Chinese to dominate the Shyok route. For once, their usual strategy of occupying the highest range would serve no tactical purpose. Therefore, if the Indo-Sinkiang trade route had to be dominated by the Chinese, they had no option but to descend towards the Shyok River, in the process occupying the entire Galwan Basin.

B. N. Mullik, the man who actually worked out the positing of Indian troops (even after Nehru’s handing over charge to the army) read the situation in the Galwan Valley correctly. Once tasked with occupying the Galwan Valley, the tenacity of 14 J&K Militia and then 1/8 Gorkha Rifles saw the men on the ground succeed in doing the impossible. Unfortunately, Mullik’s, and by extension the government’s, belief that the mere presence of Indian posts in the area was enough and the Chinese would do nothing, eventually turned the few soldiers in the region (one infantry company minus a platoon) into cannon fodder for the PLA.

Having got over the shock of finding the Indians already in the Galwan Valley, the Chinese intent was obvious after they not only encircled Galwan FDL but dug in where they were. The occupation of the Galwan Basin was obviously critical to them; neither Sinkiang Muslims nor Tibetan troops were deployed against the tiny Indian presence.